CHAPTER ONE

THE EARLY YEARS

Ratan’s Birth

In the midst of the festive season, on the ‘Holy Innocents Day’ of 28 December 1937, a baby boy was born in Chowpatty, Mumbai, to Naval and Soonoo Tata. He was named after his famous grandfather, Sir Ratan, and spent his early years in the magnificent Tata House along with his grandmother and parents. He lived like a prince, spoilt for comfort and in infinite luxury.

Situated in the Fort area on a land of nearly one and a half acres, Tata House was incomparable in terms of class, style and comfort. It was often called the Tata Palace, as it resembled one in style and splendour. This magnificent showpiece was built in the imposing Baroque style of architecture that was popular in seventeenth- and eighteenth-century Europe. The building had three floors. The top floor had exquisite Italian marble flooring and consisted mainly of two master bedrooms or suites, with dressing and cupboard rooms and bathrooms. One suite belonged to Lady Tata and the other used to be Sir Ratan’s. Sir Ratan’s suite was occupied by Naval and Soonoo. Ratan’s younger brother Jimmy, born in December 1940, had a makeshift bedroom on the same floor. It was one of the cupboard rooms attached to his parents’ suite. Young Ratan had no room to himself; the elaborate passage doubled as one for him, but it had no doors that he could shut to make it into a proper room. As the passage had no bathroom, he shared the one attached to the cupboard room that Jimmy used. Ratan’s passage often also doubled as the meeting area for the family, with his bed serving as a makeshift seat. The middle or first floor had the main reception room, a music room with a huge piano, a small sitting room and a guest suite. The ground floor had a large dining room and an